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Namo Brahmane...

नमो ब्रह्मणे नमो अस्त्वग्नये नमः पृथिव्यै नम ओषधीभ्यः ।
नमो वाचे नमो वाचस्पतये नमो विष्णवे बृहते करोमि॥

Introduction

This is the Shanti Mantra in the second chapter of the Taittiriya Aranyaka. It is also found in the body of the same chapter (Reference 2.12, 13). It is to be noted that this mantra is used as part of the practice of Brahma Yajna. Brahma Yajna is a daily Vedic practice that involves studying at least a small portion of the Vedas every day. This is done to protect the Vedic tradition by making sure the mantras learnt are not forgotten. Recalling the mantras daily amounts to repaying our debt to the Rishis who have bequeathed us this great body of wisdom. According to Acharya Sayana, this mantra, chanted towards the end of Brahma Yajna, is called the *Paridhaniya Rk*. Paridhana, according to Acharya Sayana, refers to the closing mantra. The mantras that were chanted as part of Brahma Yajna is believed to be made complete by invoking and saluting the seven divinities mentioned in this mantra.

Rishi Devata Chhandas:

These details are not available for this mantra.

Word Meaning

नमः – salutation ब्रह्मणे – to Brahman (to the Vedas or to Prajapati) नमः – Salutation अस्तु – shall be अग्नये – to Agni, नमः – Salutation, पृथिव्यै – to Earth, नमः – Salutation, ओषधीभ्यः – to the plants/herbs, नमः – salutation, वाचे – to speech, नमः – salutation, वाचस्पतये – to the Lord of Speech, नमः – salutation, विष्णवे – to Vishnu, बृहते – the all-pervasive, करोमि – I do

Translation

Salutation to Brahman (Vedas or the creator Prajapati)! Salutation to Agni! Salutation to Earth! Salutation to the plants/herbs! Salutation to Speech! Salutation to the Lord of Speech (Brihaspati)! My salutation to Vishnu the all-pervasive!

Explanation

This mantra offers salutations to seven divinities. As explained in the introduction, this mantra marks the completion of Brahma Yajna – the daily repayment of debt to the Rishis. Such a context implies that this mantra summarises the crux of the Vedic mind. We imbibe from this mantra, a reverential attitude as well as the ideals represented by the seven divinities.



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1) Brahman – the Vedas are saluted. They are the repositories of wisdom of the Vedic culture and civilisation. They have to be saluted and respected. But one is not to stop with that – they have to be learnt as well. Their meaning has to be understood and guidance for life – both material and spiritual – has to be imbibed. Those who learn this Brahman/the Vedas are Brahmanas. As Swami Vivekananda exhorts: towards such Brahminhood everyone should rise!

2) Agni – The Vedas consider Agni the presiding deity of Earth. The Vedic way of life on earth is centered on Agni. In the Vedic culture, life begins (*Vivaha agni*) and ends (*Antyeshti*) with Agni. The very first Rigvedic mantra salutes Agni as Purohita, the great benefactor. Agni also is Pavaka – the purifier. From a civilisational perspective too, it is observed that human beings graduated from being hunter-gatherers to settlers through the harnessing of fire. In the Vedas, Agni is also considered a source of inspiration – the guide to higher states of mind; that which connects humanity with divinity. Such Agni is to be saluted, and guidance sought. For a person leading a Vedic way of life, Agni thus becomes a lifelong companion that guides and purifies.

3) Prithivi – The Vedas perceive the earth as divine, and offer salutations. Indeed, Earth is our mother and the Sky above, our father. Such love towards mother Earth inspires in us an eco-friendly way of life as was lived by the Vedic sages. This connect is most essential in the current global scenario wherein we stare at a climate catastrophe due to exploitation of mother Earth and her resources.

4) Oshadhi – Herbs and plants are also divine to the Vedic sage. They are the sources of food and medicine and are sustainers and saviours of life. Their existence contributes to our welfare and our life, in turn, must nurture and contribute towards their flourishing as well.

5) Vaak – Cultured speech is a unique capability of human beings. Right speech is the manifestation of thought with *Viveka*. It is his speech that sums up the core of a person's existence and contribution as he lives on earth protected by food, medicine etc. Speech, therefore, has to be saluted and right speech has to be cultivated. This is the great life-ideal presented to us by the Vedic rishis.

6) Vacaspati – Vacaspati is saluted next. Vacaspati is Brihaspati, the preceptor of the Gods. He is also the presiding deity of mind and speech. He stands for the intellect - *vijnanam*, *buddhi*. The intellect has to be nurtured by right learning - thorough enquiry, humility and the desire to know more and refine oneself. This manifests as cultured speech.

7) Vishnu – Vishnu is derived from the root - *vish* – *vyaptau* – to pervade. This indicates the all-pervasive Pure Consciousness, which is the Ultimate Reality. The culmination of life, according to the Vedas and Upanishads, is the realisation of oneself as this Pure Consciousness. According to the Upanishads, it should be realised that Consciousness is not limited to the body – but is all pervasive – Satyam, Jnanam and Anantam (endless). Such a vision unites us all, resolves conflicts, dissolves all differences and discrimination and leads to eternal, blissful existence. This is the final destination of humanity, as presented by the rishis, through this mantra.

Thus, this mantra serves to remind the aspirant of the Vedic way of life, of the seven ideals and goals. As mentioned earlier, these seven ideals are not limited to any group of people – all of humanity can benefit by adopting these eternally relevant values in life. ✳

